

Cognitive Behavioural Coaching

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INTRODUCTION

This chapter focuses on the theory and practice of cognitive behavioural coaching (CBC). First, we endeavour to define and explain CBC, looking back on its history and acknowledging the main proponents of the tradition. Next, we outline the goals of cognitive behavioural coaching, reviewing the features and processes that set CBC apart from other approaches. Finally, we discuss the application of CBC across a range of coaching contexts. This chapter will not be describing the cognitive coaching developed by Costa and Garmston (2002) that has been applied to the teaching profession in the USA.

History and theoretical tradition

Cognitive behavioural coaching (CBC) has been defined as: *'An integrative approach which combines the use of cognitive, behavioural, imaginal and problem solving techniques and strategies within a cognitive behavioural framework to enable coachees to achieve their realistic goals'* (Palmer & Szymanska, 2007: 86).

CBC has largely developed since the 1990s, integrating theoretical concepts and strategies based on cognitive behavioural (Neenan & Palmer, 2001a; Neenan & Dryden, 2002; Edgerton & Palmer, 2005; McMahon, 2006; Palmer & Gyllensten, 2008), rational emotive behavioural (DiMattia & Mennen, 1990; Palmer & Burton, 1996; Neenan & Palmer, 2001b; Anderson, 2002;

Kodish 2002; Palmer & Gyllensten, 2008), problem (D’Zurilla, 1986; Palmer, 1997a, 1997b; Palmer, 2007, 2008), and solution focused approaches and techniques (O’Hanlon, 1998; Palmer, 2008). These were underpinned and informed by social cognitive theory (Bandura, 1986) and goal-setting theory (Locke & Latham, 1990), and by research into solution focused cognitive behavioural coaching (e.g. Grant, 2001; Green, Oades, & Grant, 2006). For further information, see the Special Issue on CBC published by the *Journal of Rational-Emotive and Cognitive-behavior Therapy* (2008: 26, 1–61).

Main assumptions of the cognitive behavioural approach

CBC is based on the premise that *‘the way you think about events profoundly influences the way you feel about them’* (Neenan and Dryden, 2002: ix), which in turn impacts upon stress and performance. Aaron T. Beck (1976) described the existence of ‘internal dialogue’, the critical inner voice in our heads that impacts our self-esteem making us doubtful of our self-efficacy (competence) and self-worth. In the 1950s, Albert Ellis (see 1994) highlighted how emotional disturbance is caused not by the activating event, but by the mediating beliefs about the activating event.

Judith Beck (1995) describes three levels of cognitions: automatic thoughts; intermediate beliefs (attitudes, rules and assumptions); and core beliefs. Both intermediate and core beliefs generally develop in early childhood (Curwen, Palmer, & Ruddell, 2000). Unhelpful cognitive ‘schema’ can lead to negative automatic ‘thoughts’ preventing us from achieving our true potential. A number of common errors of processing, better known as cognitive distortions or ‘thinking errors’, have been identified (see Box 2.1 [Palmer & Szymanska, 2007: 99–100]).

GOALS AND TASKS OF COGNITIVE BEHAVIOURAL COACHING

The main goals of CBC are to:

- 1) facilitate the client in achieving their realistic goals
- 2) facilitate self-awareness of underlying cognitive and emotional barriers to goal attainment
- 3) equip the individual with more effective thinking and behavioural skills
- 4) build internal resources, stability and self-acceptance in order to mobilize the individual to their choice of action
- 5) enable the client to become their own self-coach.

Self-awareness

In order to facilitate self-awareness of underlying cognitive and emotional barriers, the CBC coach invites the coaching client to explore the problem or issue they have difficulty with, to

Box 2.1 Example thinking errors

- Mind reading/jumping to conclusions: jumping to foregone conclusion without the relevant information, e.g. 'If I don't work overtime I'll get sacked'
- All-or-nothing thinking: evaluating experiences on the basis of extremes such as 'excellent' or 'awful', e.g. 'She always arrives late'
- Blame: not taking responsibility and blaming somebody or something else for the problem, e.g. 'It's all her fault. She should have reminded me to post the letter'
- Personalization: taking events personally, e.g. 'If our team presentation is rejected, it's my fault'
- Fortune-telling: assuming you always know what the future holds, e.g. 'I know I'll be made redundant next week'
- Emotional reasoning: mistaking feelings for facts, e.g. 'I feel so nervous, I know this merger will fall apart'
- Labelling: using labels or global ratings to describe yourself and others, e.g. 'I'm a total idiot' or 'As I failed my exam this proves I'm a complete failure'
- Demands: peppering your narrative with rigid or inflexible thinking such as 'shoulds' and 'musts': making demands of yourself and others, e.g. 'He should have made a better job of that project'
- Magnification or awfulizing: blowing events out of all proportion, e.g. 'That meeting was the worst I've ever attended. It was awful'
- Minimization: minimizing the part one plays in a situation, e.g. 'It must have been an easy exam as I got a good mark'
- Low frustration tolerance or 'I-can't-stand-it-us': we lower our tolerance to frustrating or stressful situations by telling ourselves, e.g. 'I can't stand it'
- Phoneyism: believing that you may get found out by significant others as a phoney or imposter, e.g. 'If I perform badly, they will see the real me – a total fraud'.

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examine the evidence or lack of evidence that exists in support of their current perspective on the situation and consider alternative perspectives they might generate. The questioning process used is referred to as 'Socratic' questioning, after the philosopher Socrates, and involves the coach asking a series of questions aimed at increasing awareness (Neenan & Palmer, 2001a).

Thinking skills

Thinking skills have been defined as '*methods to help you modify your stress-inducing thinking*' (Palmer & Cooper, 2007: 50). However, thinking skills also enhance performance, and increase coping and resilience. Thinking skills include inviting the coaching client to decide whether their idea or belief is logical, whether it is realistic or empirically correct (does the evidence support or refute it?) and also whether the belief is helpful (McMahon, 2007; Palmer & Szymanska, 2007).

Further thinking skills are captured by the three Ps – Perspective, Persistence and Positive thinking. Coaching clients may gain a realistic perspective by considering the question 'If X were to be true, would it really be the end of the world?', and then deciding how bad a situation

really is, as seldom are most situations really the end of the world. A 0–10 rating scale where 10 is very bad can be used to re-evaluate how bad the situation or problem seems. The coaching client may also learn to recognize self-imposed demands or rules, and to replace imperatives with preferences (Ellis & Blum, 1967; Palmer & Cooper, 2007). Given the length of time over which our core beliefs and thinking errors have become established, persistence with new more helpful ways of thinking is of great importance. Clients often reframe realistic and helpful thinking as positive thinking. Coping imagery assists clients in preparing for change (Palmer and Cooper, 2007) (see Section III).

Self-acceptance

Palmer and Cooper (2007: 77) described self-acceptance as holding the belief that *‘I’m ok, just because I exist’* and *‘I can accept myself, warts and all, with a strong preference to improve myself, even though realistically I don’t have to’*. For coaching clients self-acceptance means never globally rating themselves (e.g. good, bad, weak, strong, success, failure), only rating aspects of the self, such as skills or skills deficits, as a global rating cannot capture the complexity and uniqueness of a human being (Lazarus, 1977; Palmer, 1997c). For example a student having just heard the news they did not pass their driving examination may conclude, *‘I failed my driving test therefore I am a total failure’*, while another student in the same scenario chooses to conclude *‘I have failed my driving test, but I am ok. It just means I need to improve my driving skills and re-take the test next month’*.

SPECIFIC FEATURES, PROCESSES AND THE ROLE OF THE COACH

The dual systems approach underlying CBC enables coach and client to assess what needs to be addressed in coaching: the external, practical or goal-orientated behavioural aspects and/or the internal, psychological or cognitive aspects to a problem or issue (Neenan & Palmer, 2000). There is no need to focus on psychological aspects if a simple problem-solving model will suffice.

Behavioural models, tools and techniques

The CBC coach may initially discuss the issues with the client and then help the coaching client to develop and prioritize their SMART goals i.e. Specific, Measurable, Achievable, Realistic, Time-bound goal(s), and action plans (Locke & Latham, 1990; Favell, 2004; Schwalbe, 2005). There are a number of action-oriented coaching models used within CBC, for example Wasik’s (1984) seven-step model and the PRACTICE model (Palmer, 2007, 2008).

Table 2.1: PRACTICE model of coaching

<i>Steps</i>	<i>Questions/Statements/Actions</i>
1. Problem identification	What's the problem, issue or concern? What would you like to change? Any exceptions when it is not a problem? How will we know if the situation has improved? Any distortions? Or can the problem or issue be viewed differently?
2. Realistic, relevant goals developed (e.g. SMART goals)	What do you want to achieve? Let's develop SMART goals.
3. Alternative solutions generated	What are your options? Let's note them down.
4. Consideration of consequences	What could happen? How useful is each possible solution? Let's use a 'usefulness' rating scale for each solution where '0' is not useful at all and '10' is extremely useful.
5. Target most feasible solution(s)	What is/are the most feasible solution(s)?
6. Implementation of Chosen solution(s)	Let's implement the chosen solution by breaking it down into manageable steps. Now go and do it!
7. Evaluation	How successful was it? Use a success rating scale 0 to 10. What can be learnt? Can we finish coaching now or do you want to address or discuss another issue?

Source: Palmer, 2007, 2008 (reproduced with permission).

PRACTICE is an acronym for a problem-solving and solution focused model that has been used within coaching, counselling, psychotherapy and stress management (Palmer, 2007, 2008). The sequential steps of the PRACTICE model facilitate the coaching conversation and help orientate the client towards understanding the problem, developing realistic goals, selecting feasible solutions and their implementation, and finally reviewing progress. Table 2.1 provides an outline of each step in the model and summarizes key questions that may be used to facilitate discussion.

The early behaviour therapists Joseph Wolpe and Arnold Lazarus (Wolpe & Lazarus, 1966) developed a number of behavioural techniques to assist clients to relax, reduce anxiety and overcome phobias by using progressive relaxation and systematic desensitization. Although these are usually considered therapeutic interventions, a cognitive behavioural coach may use relaxation techniques and encourage clients to develop cognitive and behavioural coping strategies; and to expose themselves in imagination and *in vivo* to anxiety triggering situations, such as giving presentations or chairing meetings, which would not normally be associated with clinical disorders. Personal experimentation is encouraged in a bid to help clients incorporate new and more functional ways of thinking and behaving. Wolpe also introduced the concept and practice of assertiveness training that continues as an important component of CBC (Wolpe, 1973). Behavioural approaches to relaxation (Poppen, 1998) have an important role in CBC. Helping a client breathe well is one method used to help clients manage anxiety and panic tendencies in stressful or high performance situations.

Table 2.2: Example of PITS and PETS for making a presentation

<i>Performance interfering thoughts (PITS)</i>	<i>Performance enhancing thoughts (PETS)</i>
It's going to go badly	It will be at least okay
I'm terrible at making presentations	Some have gone well, some less well but overall I'm reasonable at making presentations
Visions of being unable to speak and of being laughed at	Visions of making the presentation with a mistake or two, but overall going well
The audience will be bored	How do I know? I haven't even given the presentation yet!

Cognitive models, tools and techniques

There is a range of different cognitive models, tools and techniques, a number of which are covered in this section. Coaching clients may be helped to recognize patterns of unhelpful thinking by first identifying Performance Interfering Thoughts (PITS) in order to generate alternative Performance Enhancing Thoughts (PETS) (Neenan & Palmer, 2001a). Table 2.2 provides an example of the PITS/PETS activity for a coaching client with a fear of making presentations.

The ABCDEF model (Ellis, Gordon, Neenan, & Palmer, 1997; Palmer, 2002; 2009) of the rational emotive behaviour approach allows the coach to facilitate a review of the event that triggers psychological disturbance for the coaching client, in order to identify unhelpful thinking patterns and replace these with more constructive thoughts and behaviours (see Neenan & Dryden, 2002; Palmer & Szymanska, 2007).

The model is based on Albert Ellis's ABC model of emotional disturbance (Ellis et al., 1997), whereby an individual typically assumes a direct link between A, the Activating event or an Awareness of a problem or issue, and C, the emotional and/or behavioural and/or physical Consequence, when in actuality this relationship is mediated by B, the Beliefs and perceptions about the activating event. D is about Disputing or examining the beliefs, while E is about developing an Effective, new response or change in behaviour. The ABCDEF model also includes F, representing a Future focus on personal work goals and the learning from ABCDE – '*what the employee has learnt from the process to ensure that they are less likely to become stressed by a similar event in the future*' (Palmer, 2002: 16). Figure 2.1 depicts an example of the ABCDEF model in use for a coaching client as part of a stress management and prevention programme.

The ABCDEF framework is a model of stress, performance, coping and resilience depending upon its application. In practice goals are developed early on in the process and this is often depicted as G-ABCDEF framework. The coaching client is often shown this model using an A4 landscape, five or six column form, noting down the client's problem, beliefs, consequences, modified beliefs, effective new approach and future focus.

The SPACE model was developed by Nick Edgerton (Edgerton & Palmer, 2005). Its development was influenced by Multimodal Therapy (Lazarus 1989) and the Five Aspect Model described by Dennis Greenberger and Christine Padesky (1995). SPACE is a cognitive behavioural framework revolving around a diagram designed to help individuals become aware of

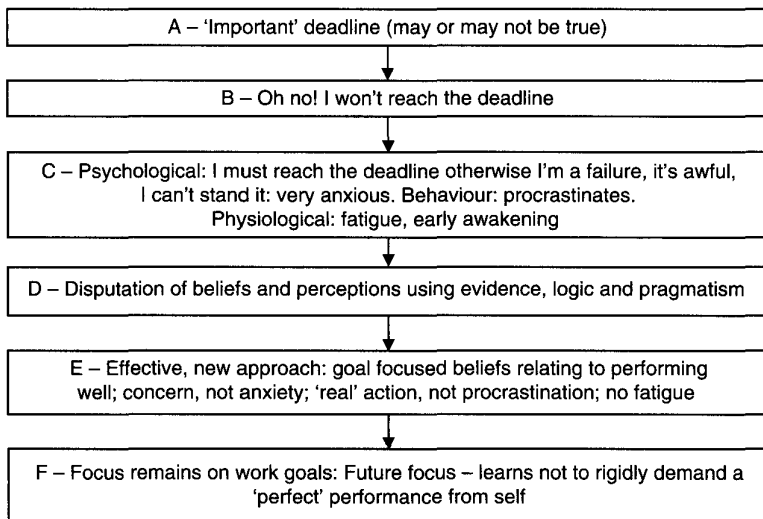


Figure 2.1 Client example using the ABCDEF model.

Source: Palmer, 2002.

their dysfunctional patterns, and can be used to plan more effective ways of functioning. SPACE is an acronym for five key aspects of the model, as follows:

- S** Social context and Situation
- P** Physical & Physiological reaction; for instance low/high arousal, e.g. high heart rate, breathing difficulties, sleep deprivation, fatigue, nausea, tightness in chest, dry mouth, headache, sweating, hormones
- A** Action/Inaction; e.g. avoidance behaviours, passive or aggressive behaviours
- C** Cognitions; automatic thoughts, attitudes and assumptions, core beliefs
- E** Emotions; e.g. anxiety, anger, depression, fear, shame, embarrassment, guilt

The model incorporates a series of nested models of Actions, Cognitions & Emotions (ACE), and with the added dimension, Physical/Physiological (PACE) (Edgerton & Palmer, 2005).

One of the benefits of the SPACE model comes through the deployment of multi-aspect intervention strategies. The coaching client is encouraged to review each of the five areas and to agree how and what they would choose to do differently in each area. Figures 2.2 and 2.3 provide examples of the SPACE model, depicting in turn both low and high performance states.

Lazarus described how *‘through the proper use of mental imagery, one can achieve an immediate sense of self confidence, develop more energy and stamina, and tap one’s own mind for numerous productive purposes’* (Lazarus, 1984: 3). There is a range of imagery techniques including: Goal imagery (Palmer & Puri, 2006); Motivation imagery (Palmer & Neenan, 1998); Anger reducing imagery (Palmer & Puri, 2006); Coping imagery (Lazarus, 1984; Palmer & Puri, 2006);

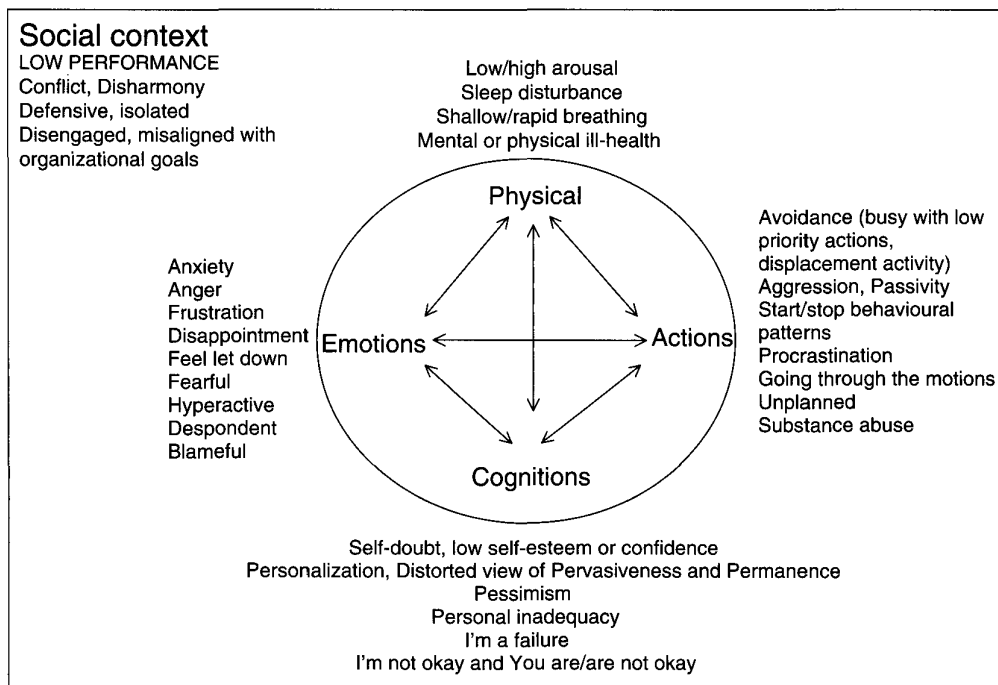


Figure 2.2 Depiction of low performance state using the SPACE model.

Relaxation imagery (Lazarus, 1982; Palmer, Cooper & Thomas, 2003); and Time projection imagery (Lazarus, 1984, 1989; Palmer & Cooper, 2007).

The role of the coach

Neenan & Palmer describe how the cognitive behavioural approach '*is based on a collaborative relationship that helps individuals to focus on problem-solving in a structured and systematic way*' (Neenan & Palmer, 2001a: 17). Through Socratic questioning, active participation and discussion (Roberts & Billings, 1999) the coach supports and challenges the client to achieve heightened awareness, self-esteem, self-acceptance and mobility to act. Through the transfer of the knowledge and skills of cognitive behavioural coaching, the coach is able to facilitate the ultimate goal '*for individuals to become their own coach*' (Neenan & Palmer, 2001a).

It is important to establish a clear contract, both with the coaching client and, where relevant, the line manager or organizational sponsor. This type of 'triad' coaching contract typically includes agreement of objectives of coaching engagement, outcome measurements, feedback

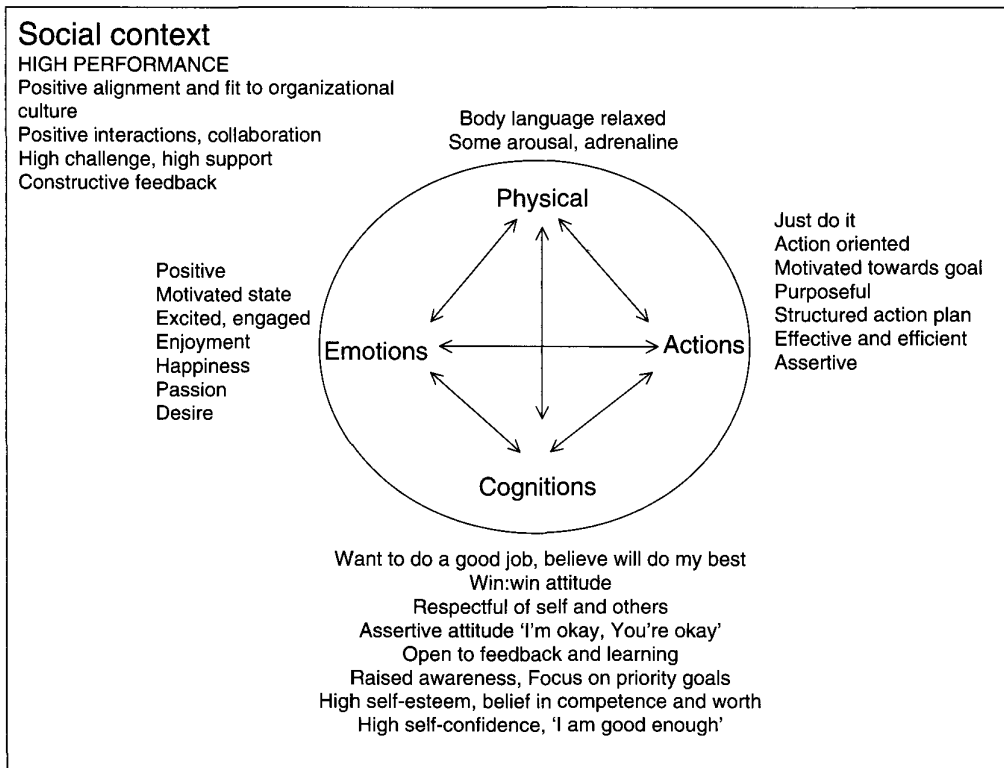


Figure 2.3 Depiction of high performance state using the SPACE model.

procedures and confidentiality, and is best agreed by all parties (McMahon, 2005). It is likely that a set number of coaching sessions or hours will be agreed so that each engagement is clear and purposeful. Lengths of sessions may vary from 30 to 120 minutes, often with a series of six to eight sessions over a time period of four to six months (see Palmer & Szymanska, 2007).

COMPARISON OF TRADITIONS

The CBC approach has a distinct psychological management model at its core, which most coaching clients find easy to learn and adopt. The techniques and strategies are systematically applied depending upon the particular issue the client needs to address.

CBC is a direct approach in that goal-blocking thoughts, feelings and behaviours, and the links between, are identified, examined and then modified. The client is encouraged to put

these changes into practice as soon as possible through a series of planned exposures and experiments.

The directness of CBC is in contrast to other approaches such as psychodynamic and person centred coaching, with the Socratic challenges standing out in contrast to the empathic responses that are the hallmark of the person centred approach (Joseph, 2006). Empathy is important in CBC; however, it is not emphasized as much as in the person centred approach and is normally coupled with the direct challenges illustrated above. Person centred approaches are likely to rely on the client eventually challenging him/herself but this can take time and may not occur spontaneously. The use of exposure or behavioural experimentation, combined with cognitive interventions, is another characteristic of CBC that contrasts with other approaches, such as psychodynamic and person centred.

CONTEXTS

Cognitive Behavioural Coaching may be used in the majority of the contexts identified in the book's introduction. It can also be used for health coaching. Wherever a client is disturbing or limiting him/herself by unhelpful thinking, or engaging in self-defeating behaviours that undermine their performance, CBC can be a powerful coaching intervention.

Skills and performance

In skills and performance contexts a client can easily begin to doubt him/herself, thinking: 'I'm not good enough', 'I'm about to fail', and/or 'any moment now my performance will collapse'. Imagery may include others criticizing them and showing disapproval, while anticipated emotions, such as shame and embarrassment, may be experienced and sooner or later their performance will falter or be impaired by avoidance or procrastination. CBC teaches the client to both recognize and correct these self-disturbances.

Life coaching

In life coaching, clients explore their life goals and review their progress against these goals. Often the limiting factor to progress is the client's self-limiting beliefs. The CBC approach would be to recognize that the client is thinking and behaving in ways that are self-defeating or limiting. The client would then be helped to see how they could think about themselves in ways that would enhance their confidence and self-esteem before deliberately engaging in personal experiments designed to develop and enhance confidence to take action towards achieving their life goals.

Developmental

Developmental coaching for executives often focuses on professional and personal transformation within the context of the executive's job and organization (Sperry, 2004). CBC can provide insight into personal beliefs that influence the executive and their team and may block transformation. CBC can facilitate the adult's understanding of their emotions, helping them to comprehend the links between thoughts and emotions, and to learn how to express themselves emotionally and make requests of others in an appropriately assertive manner (Wolpe & Lazarus, 1966; Wolpe, 1973).

Executive and leadership

Executives and leaders in organizations need to be or become skilful in managing their own psychological processes, to manage emotions such as anxiety, frustration and anger, and to maintain an appropriate level of self-confidence without becoming complacent, arrogant or narcissistic. They are more likely to be effective in their roles if they develop high levels of interpersonal, influencing and communication skills. CBC can be helpful in all of these processes as the client learns to become increasingly skilful in managing the interaction between their own actions, cognitions and emotions.

Peer coaching

Peer coaching can come in many forms. For example, within teaching in the UK, peer coaching was set up by the National Union of Teachers on the Teacher2Teacher continuing professional development programme as a collaborative and normally formalized process between two peers to support each other (National Union of Teachers, 2008). It provides a structured framework to provide feedback on each other's work and includes suggestions on informed professional dialogue. This particular approach is on the more behavioural spectrum of coaching, but in other settings the cognitive skills could be introduced. As CBC is a pragmatic and transparent approach, peers can use the theory, models and techniques on each other within peer coaching.

Team coaching

CBC adapts very easily to group settings as it is both insight and skills based with relatively easy to understand theory and models such as the G-ABCDEF, SPACE and PRACTICE as previously described. Depending upon the team concerned, it can be used to enhance performance and manage stress. The coach facilitates the group to look at both team and

individual issues. Members can work in pairs when looking at their own particular issues. This has a secondary gain for the organization, as supervisors and managers start to learn how to use cognitive behavioural coaching skills and techniques on themselves, each other and subsequently their own team.

Career coaching

Career coaching can occur across the entire young person and adult spectrum of life. Often, people benefit from career coaching as they make transitions from school to college, from college to work, then from job to job or redundancy to a new career. These transitions are now more prevalent in modern society, as adults are less likely to remain in the same job or even career for a long period of time. The PRACTICE and SPACE models of CBC have been applied to career coaching, for example when a client has been hesitant to make the move from one job to another or to decide upon a new profession.

Coaching and managing

Managers can usefully incorporate coaching strategies and skills into their repertoire. If a manager learns how to apply CBC to him/herself, it puts them in a good place to begin to use the same principles and techniques with their team. If, for example, one of their team is continually late finishing assignments and the manager simply puts the pressure on, it could be counterproductive. A CBC analysis of what is happening might identify a perfectionist demand, either on the part of the manager, the team member or both. Once identified, these demands can be modified to preferential statements and softened to 'good enough', 'fit for purpose', contributing to a learning culture within the team.

Health coaching

Health coaching has been described as '*the practice of health education and health promotion within a coaching context, underpinned by psychological principles, to enhance the well-being of individuals and to facilitate the achievement of their health-related goals*' (Palmer, Tubbs & Whybrow, 2003: 92). Health coaching is now being used within organizational and company settings to help employees tackle health-related issues such as weight control, nutrition, blood pressure, alcohol intake and smoking. This has enabled some American companies to prevent large rises in their annual staff health insurance premiums and demonstrates a noticeable return on investment.

CBC adapts very easily to the field of health coaching (Palmer et al., 2003b; Palmer, 2004). Motivational interviewing is used to engage and motivate clients to address their health-related

issues (Miller & Rollnick, 1991). Cognitive behavioural coaching techniques and strategies are often used to tackle psychological blocks to goal achievement by examining the client's Health Inhibiting Thinking (HITs) and then helping them to develop Health Enhancing Thinking (HETs) (Palmer, 2004).

EVALUATION OF THE TRADITION

While the responsibility for change rests at many levels (government, society, organizations and the individual), CBC offers support directly to the individual by equipping them with coping strategies and thinking skills to ready them to achieve their full potential. The applications of CBC are varied, from building confidence and being assertive to tackling blocks to performance such as procrastination, perfectionism and poor time management; reducing unhelpful emotional reactions such as excessive anger or anxiety; or helping to achieve broader life goals.

Palmer and Whybrow (see 2007) researched the prevalence of coaching practices as used by practicing coaching psychologists between 2003 and 2007. They found that cognitive, behavioural and cognitive behavioural approaches were consistently in the top six most popular approaches used. In 2007, the most popular approaches were solution focused and facilitation methods, followed by the cognitive behavioural approach. Each of these methods was reportedly used by over 60% of the coaching psychologist population who completed the online survey.

In 2001, Anthony Grant recommended that researchers investigate whether a '*combined cognitive-behavioural coaching approach [is] effective in helping adults reach "real life" such as establishing businesses or enhancing work performance*' (Grant, 2001: 17). Over the last decade CBC has met this challenge, firmly establishing itself as a coaching practice recognized in its own right. Initially borrowing from the academic and applied research of CBT, there is now a growing body of evidence to directly support the value and effectiveness of CBC.

Anthony Grant has conducted a controlled study comparing cognitive, behavioural and cognitive behavioural approaches to coaching for trainee accountants (Grant, 2001). The follow-up study found '*academic performance increases were maintained only for combined cognitive and behavioural program participants*' (Grant, 2001: 1). In a further controlled study on the effects of a ten-week cognitive behavioural, solution-focused life-coaching group programme, significant increases in goal striving, well-being and hope were found for those receiving coaching, with some of the effects being evident up to thirty weeks later (Green et al., 2006). A study of the efficacy of cognitive behavioural coaching for perfectionism and self-handicapping reported that perfectionism fell and the effect was still evident four weeks later; self-handicapping showed a significant reduction at four weeks (Kearns et al., 2007). Green, Grant, & Rynsaardt (2007) found that solution-focused cognitive behavioural coaching enhanced cognitive hardiness and hope, with significant decreases in depression, in high school students.

Grbcic (Grbcic and Palmer, 2007) developed a stress self-coaching manual for middle managers, based on the cognitive behavioural approach. Four outcome measures were used to measure change: Brief Symptom Inventory (BSI; primary outcome measure); Symptom Assessment-45 (SA45); Coping Inventory for Stressful Situations (CISS); and the Job Stress Survey (JSS). Significant changes were obtained on the BSI ($P < 0.001$) at post-treatment, as well as on the SA45 ($P < 0.001$), indicating intervention effectiveness regardless of the frequency of work stressors and lack of organizational support. Measures of coping indicated that the intervention increased task, emotion, and distraction-oriented coping styles ($P < 0.001$). No coach, trainer or counsellor was used to teach the self-help approach. This highlights how alternative media may be considered to transfer the benefits usually derived from an actual coach–client relationship.

CBC provides clients with new ways of realizing how they are limiting themselves and their performance. In so doing it helps the client reduce any tendency to blame others or circumstances instead of accepting responsibility for themselves and their own self-disturbing and self-limiting habits. With this new acceptance that ‘it’s me doing it to myself’, comes the realization that ‘I can decide to change and become more effective in life’.

As with all coaching models and techniques, cognitive behavioural coaching is only appropriate to use when the coach is CBC trained and is in receipt of supervision, when the coaching contract has been clearly established and the CBC methods explained in non-jargon terms to the coaching client, with their affirmation of interest to pursue this line of enquiry.

CBC will not be necessary where action-oriented models will suffice to generate the desired change in behaviour, and will not be appropriate where the coaching client expresses:

- a need to revisit and address the past, requiring a more psychodynamic approach
- a desire to focus on greater meaning and purpose, where an existential approach will be more aligned to their needs
- an explicit interest in positive psychology and coaching, which may be at odds with the CBC theoretical assumption that negative cognitions and emotions need to be explored in order to be addressed.

Cognitive behavioural coaching is most likely to fail when the coaching client has a clinical disorder or is not accepting either the emotional responsibility for the problems they bring to coaching or the coaching responsibility for taking action (Palmer & Szymanska, 2007).

The following scenarios are examples of when a cognitive behavioural coaching approach may be of most benefit:

- when action models of coaching are not enough to bring about change
- when there is a cognitive or emotional block to achieving full potential
- when current levels of anxiety/avoidance are negatively impacting on performance
- when levels of stress are impacting upon mental and physical health.

CBC provides clients with the conceptual tools to better understand themselves; it also provides vehicles for change through personal experimentation and exposure to situations that previously

they may have avoided. Clients will still have to work hard and be vigilant to establish their new ways of thinking and behaving.

FURTHER READING

- Neenan, M., & Dryden, W. (2002). *Life coaching: A cognitive behavioural approach*. Hove: Routledge. (This book provides a comprehensive summary of cognitive behavioural models and significant challenges that may be addressed using cognitive behavioural coaching.)
- Palmer, S., & Whybrow, A. (2007). *Handbook of coaching psychology: A guide for practitioners*. Hove: Routledge. (This handbook includes a chapter on 'cognitive behavioural coaching: an integrated approach' offering a comprehensive outline of the founding theories, proponents and research of CBC, with descriptions of various CBC models and case examples.)
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